

IN THE SENATE

SENATE CONCURRENT RESOLUTION NO. 117

BY RESOURCES AND ENVIRONMENT COMMITTEE

A CONCURRENT RESOLUTION

STATING FINDINGS OF THE LEGISLATURE REGARDING WATER DISTRICT 4 AND SUPPORT-
ING VARIOUS ASSOCIATED PROJECTS.

Be It Resolved by the Legislature of the State of Idaho:

WHEREAS, Water District 4 of the Idaho Water Resource Board (IWRB), en-
compassing the headwaters of the Snake River system in East Idaho including
Bonneville, Bingham, Jefferson, Madison, Fremont, Clark, Power, Bannock,
Caribou, Oneida, Franklin, Bear Lake, and Teton counties, serves as the pri-
mary "water tower" for the agricultural and economic prosperity of Southern
Idaho; and

WHEREAS, the region is home to the world-renowned Henrys Fork and South
Fork of the Snake River, supporting a premier recreational economy while si-
multaneously providing the essential irrigation water for the state's mas-
sive potato and grain production sectors; and

WHEREAS, IWRB has identified, funded, and overseen numerous projects
critical to optimizing water storage, enhancing winter snowpack, and
recharging the Eastern Snake Plain Aquifer (ESPA) at its hydrologic source.

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED by the members of the Second Regular Ses-
sion of the Sixty-eighth Idaho Legislature, the Senate and the House of Rep-
resentatives concurring therein, that the Legislature hereby formally rec-
ognizes the importance of and supports the continuation of water projects
within Water District 4.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature prioritizes the continued
expansion and optimization of managed aquifer recharge infrastructure in
the Upper Snake River Valley and specifically supports the ongoing develop-
ment of recharge sites on the Henrys Fork River, Teton River, and main stem of
the Snake River above American Falls Reservoir that benefit reach gains to
the Snake River, as well as IWRB's continued efforts to identify additional
recharge locations.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature acknowledges that capturing
early season runoff and injecting it into the aquifer in District 4 is the
most effective method for sustaining ground water levels across the entire
Eastern Snake Plain, thereby benefiting users hundreds of miles downstream.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature commends surface water and
ground water users for their efforts to find meaningful long-term solutions
and recognizes that these IWRB funds are a key to the success of the 2024
Stipulated Mitigation Plan.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature supports the Upper Snake
River Cloud Seeding Program and recognizes this as a sophisticated, cost-ef-
fective technology that enhances winter snowpack in the high-elevation
watersheds. This program, which occurs only in the high mountain ranges
during the winter season, is a critical active management strategy that

1 increases the total water budget available for storage, recharge, and irri-
2 gation during the dry summer months.

3 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature commends the collaborative
4 efforts regarding the Upper Snake Basin Study and associated storage opti-
5 mization initiatives and acknowledges the importance of identifying new or
6 enhanced surface water storage opportunities and water marketing strategies
7 to mitigate the impacts of increasingly variable precipitation patterns in
8 this high-altitude basin.

9 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature acknowledges the vital im-
10 provements made through Aging Infrastructure Grants to irrigation entities
11 in East Idaho, including the Bear River Valley. The Legislature recognizes
12 that the rehabilitation of major diversion structures and the automation of
13 canal headgates are essential for precise water management, including the
14 modernization efforts of the Progressive Irrigation District and the Enter-
15 prise Canal Company. These projects not only prevent system failure but al-
16 low for the tight control necessary to deliver water rights and facilitate
17 aquifer recharge operations with less waste.

18 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature declares these projects
19 collectively vital to the strategic interests of District 4 as they, among
20 other benefits:

21 (1) Secure the water supply. By enhancing snowpack and capturing
22 runoff, these projects increase the total volume of water available to the
23 state;

24 (2) Sustain the aquifer. District 4 serves as the primary recharge zone
25 for the upper portion of the ESPA and the recharge program supports the ob-
26 jectives of the 2024 Stipulated Mitigation Plan, a prerequisite for success
27 in Water District 3; and

28 (3) Modernize delivery. Investments in canal infrastructure ensure
29 that the region's agricultural producers remain globally competitive.

30 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature emphasizes that as the head-
31 waters of the Snake River system, District 4 requires robust and consistent
32 funding to maintain the storage and recharge infrastructure on which the en-
33 tire southern portion of the state relies.

34 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature recognizes that the main-
35 tenance of water security requires a sustained commitment to future invest-
36 ment, particularly as District 4 faces the compounding pressures of hydro-
37 logic variability and increased demand, and that proactive funding for plan-
38 ning, modernization, and aquifer management is fiscally responsible and es-
39 sential to prevent the significantly higher costs associated with deferred
40 maintenance and emergency response.

41 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature supports the continued ap-
42 propriation of funds to IWRB to ensure the completion and long-term viabil-
43 ity of critical projects in Water District 4.